

DRTAN LM Architect — Website Project Brief

Client: DRTAN LM Architect (Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia) **Domain:** dtlm.com.my (already registered, currently serving an existing site) **Status:** Rebuild / replacement of existing site
Date: August 2026

Purpose of this document. This is the founding brief for the project. Hand it to Claude Cowork at the start of the session and ask it to read this file first and keep it in project context. Every technical decision below is deliberate — if Cowork proposes an alternative, it should say why and check with you before deviating.

1. Context

DRTAN LM Architect is an established Malaysian practice led by Ar. Dr. Tan Loke Mun, recipient of the **PAM Gold Medal 2025** and an **ARCASIA Awards for Architecture 2025** Honorary Mention (Clay Roof House, Incheon, South Korea). The firm has significant press coverage — Tatler Asia, The Edge, The Star, Architizer, Architecture Malaysia, designspeak.asia.

This matters for scope: the existing site carries real SEO equity and a deep archive of press and awards. This is not a greenfield build; it is a migration.

Design direction

Reference sites supplied by the client:

Reference	What to draw from it
pholc.com	Calm editorial grid, generous whitespace, restrained typography (note: a lighting brand, not a firm)
tkca.com.my	Local peer context, Malaysian market expectations
heatherwick.com	Full-bleed image-led presentation, images carrying the narrative

Synthesis: quiet, typographic, generous whitespace, images doing the talking. Minimal chrome. No carousels, no parallax, no scroll-jacking.

2. Non-negotiable requirements

1. **Works with JavaScript disabled.** All content readable, all navigation functional, contact form submittable. JavaScript is progressive enhancement only — never a dependency for content or core function.
 2. **WCAG 2.2 Level AA conformance.**
 3. **Responsive from 360px to 2560px.**
 4. **Minimal running cost.** Target: domain renewal only. No WordPress, no Hubspot, no SaaS site builders.
 5. **Non-developer maintainable** by a tech-savvy person following written documentation.
 6. **Portable.** The output is static files; changing hosts must be trivial.
-

3. Technical stack

Site generator: Astro

Why: ships zero JavaScript by default (directly serves requirement 1), has a best-in-class build-time image pipeline (responsive [srcset](#), AVIF/WebP conversion, lazy loading — critical for an image-led portfolio), and allows interactivity as isolated islands only where genuinely needed.

Do not use: Next.js, Gatsby, or any React SPA framework. They invert the JS-resilience requirement.

Content: Markdown files with frontmatter, in the repository

Decision note — this overrides the earlier Google Sheets idea, deliberately.

A spreadsheet-as-CMS pattern earns its keep at 50+ frequently-changing records. At ~5–12 projects it adds a network dependency, an API key, a rate limit, and a second system to document, in exchange for nothing. Markdown files in the repo are simpler, version-controlled, diffable, work offline, and have no external failure mode.

If a visual editing UI becomes necessary later, add **Keystatic** or **Sveltia CMS** on top. Both are free, git-based, provide a browser form-based editor, commit directly to GitHub, and require no change to the underlying content files. This is the designed upgrade path — do not architect around it now.

Critical rule regardless of source: all content is read **at build time**, never fetched from the browser at runtime. Runtime fetching produces a blank page without JS and fails requirement 1.

Images: in-repository for now

At ~5–12 images this is entirely appropriate. Structure:

src/content/projects/ # markdown, one file per project

src/assets/projects/ # source images, committed

Astro processes source images at build time into optimised responsive variants. Originals never ship to the browser.

Constraints to observe:

- Cap committed source images at ~2500px on the long edge and under ~2MB each. Do not commit 40MB photographer originals — keep those in the firm's own archive.
- GitHub soft limits: ~1GB repository, 100GB/month bandwidth. Fine at this scale; revisit if the gallery grows past ~200 images.
- **Migration trigger:** if total image weight approaches ~500MB, move to Cloudflare Images or S3 + CloudFront. Keep image paths abstracted behind a single config value so this is a one-file change.

Hosting: Cloudflare Pages

Recommended over GitHub Pages, despite the original plan. Both are free and both deploy from the same GitHub repository, but Cloudflare Pages handles apex domains and HTTPS more cleanly, has better global CDN performance into Southeast Asia, and gives more generous bandwidth headroom.

On the eventual S3 move: note that S3 alone cannot serve HTTPS on a custom domain — it requires CloudFront plus an ACM certificate. That is more moving parts and more cost than Cloudflare Pages, for no gain at this scale. Reconsider only if there's an organisational reason to consolidate on AWS.

Either way the build artifact is plain static files, so switching later is trivial.

Contact form

Static hosting has no server. Use a third-party POST endpoint — **Web3Forms** or **Formspree** (both have adequate free tiers).

Implementation requirement: a plain `<form action="..." method="POST">` that submits without JavaScript. Do not implement as a JS `fetch` handler. Include a honeypot field for spam. Confirm the endpoint's data handling is acceptable before committing.

Analytics

Cloudflare Web Analytics (free, cookieless) or **Plausible**. Cookieless means no consent banner — one fewer accessibility obstacle and one fewer PDPA question.

4. Site structure

/	Home	
/projects/	Project index	
/projects/[slug]/	Individual project	
/about/	About the practice	
/team/	People & bios	
/contact/	Contact	
/news/	News, awards & press	[see §5]
/accessibility/	Accessibility statement	
/privacy/	Privacy notice	

Home

Hero image, brief positioning statement, selected projects, recent awards/press. Restrained — one clear path into the work.

Projects index

Grid of project cards. Each card: image, name, location, year.

Filtering: if filtering by typology is wanted, implement as **real URL routes** (`/projects/residential/`) rendered at build time, with optional JS enhancement layered on top. A client-side filter leaves an empty grid when JS is off.

Project detail

Hero image plus an expandable detail panel.

Implementation — use the native `<details>/<summary>` element. It expands and collapses with zero JavaScript, is keyboard-operable, and is announced correctly by screen readers without any ARIA. Style it, don't rebuild it. A custom JS accordion would fail both the JS-resilience and accessibility requirements.

About / Team

Practice history, philosophy, credentials. Team page with Ar. Dr. Tan Loke Mun as principal, plus staff bios and headshots.

Contact

Address, phone, email, map link, enquiry form. Do not embed a Google Maps iframe — it's a heavy third-party JS dependency and an accessibility problem. Use a static map image linked to Google Maps.

5. News / Awards / Press — decide before building

The existing site carries a substantial archive: PAM Gold Medal 2025, ARCASIA 2025, Tatler Asia, The Edge, The Star, BFM, Architizer, Architecture Malaysia, speaking engagements.

This is genuine reputational asset and should not be silently dropped. Three options:

1. **Full migration** — port all posts as Markdown. Most work, preserves everything.
2. **Curated awards & press page** — a single page listing awards, publications and speaking engagements with outbound links. Recommended: ~80% of the value for ~20% of the effort.
3. **Defer** — build the template, populate later. Acceptable only if redirects are handled (see §9).

Decision required from client before build starts.

6. Project content model

Every project uses this frontmatter schema. Fields marked **required** must be enforced by Astro's content collection schema so a build fails rather than shipping incomplete data.

title: # required

slug: # required, URL-safe

year: # required

location: # required — city, country

client: # optional (check confidentiality)

status: # required — built | under-construction | competition | unbuilt

typology: # required — residential | commercial | civic | institutional | interior

area: # optional, sqm

description: # required — body content, Markdown

heroImage: # required — path to source image

heroImageAlt: # REQUIRED — see below

photographer: # required if image is not in-house

awards: [] # optional

publications: [] # optional

team: [] # optional

consultants: [] # optional

featured: # boolean — surface on homepage

order: # integer — manual sort control

Two fields that must be mandatory

heroImageAlt — meaningful alt text is the WCAG criterion most likely to fail on an image-led site, and the only reliable fix is making it impossible to publish without. Enforce in schema. Alt text should describe the architectural subject, not repeat the project title.

photographer — architectural photography is licensed, and credit lines are typically contractual. Confirm the firm holds web usage rights for every image before publication. This is a legal exposure, not a nicety.

7. Accessibility specification

Target: WCAG 2.2 Level AA.

There is currently no private-sector web accessibility mandate in Malaysia — WCAG 2.1 AA requirements attach to government digital services. However, the Ministry of Communications has signalled movement toward broader standards, and a conformance statement is a tangible advantage when bidding institutional and government-linked work.

Specific traps for this site type

- **Contrast.** Architecture sites gravitate toward light grey on white. Body text needs **4.5:1** minimum, large text 3:1. Test every combination; do not eyeball it.
- **Text over images.** Hero overlays routinely fail contrast. Use a scrim or a solid caption block.
- **Alt text.** Every image. Decorative images get `alt=""`.
- **Keyboard navigation.** Every interactive element reachable and operable by keyboard, in logical order.
- **Visible focus indicators.** Do not remove outlines. Style them to match the design.
- **Skip link** to main content.
- **Semantic landmarks** — `<header>`, `<nav>`, `<main>`, `<footer>`; one `<h1>` per page; no heading level skips.
- **prefers-reduced-motion** honoured for all transitions.
- **No auto-advancing carousels.**
- **Target size** minimum 24×24px (WCAG 2.2).
- **Text resize to 200%** without loss of content or function.
- **lang="en"** on `<html>`. Add `lang` attributes on any Malay or Chinese passages.

Verification before launch

- axe DevTools or Lighthouse on every template

- Full keyboard-only pass
- Screen reader pass (NVDA or VoiceOver) on home, project detail, contact
- Manual contrast check on all text/background pairs

Automated tools catch roughly a third of issues. The manual passes are not optional.

8. Performance budget

- Under **1MB** total page weight on first load
 - **LCP under 2.5s** on 4G
 - **Zero JavaScript** on content pages unless a specific feature justifies it
 - All images served as AVIF/WebP with responsive `srcset`
 - Self-host fonts; no Google Fonts CDN call
-

9. Migration & launch

1. **Crawl the existing site** and export a complete URL inventory before touching anything.
 2. **Build a redirect map** from old URLs to new. Cloudflare Pages supports a `_redirects` file. Losing project and press URLs means losing accumulated search ranking.
 3. **Preserve or reproduce press content** per the §5 decision.
 4. **Verify domain control** — check registrant via the MYNIC WHOIS lookup (`.com.my` is administered by MYNIC, not global registrars), and separately identify who controls DNS. These may be different parties.
 5. **Staging deployment first** on a Cloudflare Pages preview URL for client review.
 6. **DNS cutover** only after sign-off.
 7. **Post-launch:** submit updated sitemap to Google Search Console; monitor 404s for two weeks.
-

10. Open items

- ☐ **Firm name** — "DRTAN LM Architect" (per current site) vs "DTLM Architect" (per brief). Confirm exact legal and display form.
- ☐ **Project count at launch** — 5 was proposed; 8–12 is more appropriate for a practice of this standing. Confirm available material.
- ☐ **News/press decision** — §5, options 1/2/3.

- ☐ **Brand assets** — logo in SVG, brand colours, typeface. **Note: desktop font licences do not cover web embedding.** Either budget for a webfont licence or select from open-source families.
 - ☐ **Image rights** — confirm web usage rights and required credit lines for all photography.
 - ☐ **Language** — English only, or Bahasa Malaysia as well?
 - ☐ **Who maintains DNS** currently.
 - ☐ **Privacy notice** — required once the contact form is live; consider Malaysian PDPA obligations.
-

11. Documentation deliverable

A [README.md](#) in the repository is a required deliverable, not an optional extra. The most common failure mode for a site like this is the one person who understood the setup becoming unavailable.

It must cover:

- How to add a new project (step by step, with a copyable template file)
 - How to add a team member
 - Image preparation: required dimensions, format, file size, naming convention
 - How to write good alt text, with three worked examples
 - How to preview changes locally
 - How deployment works and how to confirm it succeeded
 - How to roll back a bad deploy
 - Where the domain, DNS, form endpoint and analytics accounts live, and who has access
 - Pre-publication checklist: alt text present, photographer credited, contrast checked, mobile verified
-

12. Instructions for Cowork

- Read this file first and keep it in project context for the duration.
- **Do not** introduce a client-side JavaScript framework for content rendering.
- **Do not** fetch content from an external API at runtime.
- Use `<details>/<summary>` for expandable content rather than a custom JS accordion.
- Enforce `heroImageAlt` and `photographer` in the content schema so builds fail on omission.

- Build the accessibility statement and privacy pages as part of the initial scope, not afterwards.
- Produce the README as a first-class deliverable.
- Where a decision in §10 is unresolved, build the template and stub the content — flag it rather than inventing placeholder copy that might ship.